



Appendix K. Personnel Security Program FAQs

Introduction

In 2004 when the Personnel Security program for Auxiliarists was implemented, there were many questions. The “Frequently Asked Questions” core document was created and posted on the Chief Director’s web site to help all Auxiliarists better understand the program through accurate and consistent answers to their questions. The following FAQs constitute that initial core list. The master FAQ list remains on the Chief Director’s web site in a “living dynamic” state allowing for the inclusion of new FAQs and answers as this Personnel Security Program initiative matures. See *Chapter 3, Section C* of this manual for more information.





Question or Issue	Response or Explanation
Why is this necessary and why now?	• 9-11; Heightened security requirements. • Move to DHS. • To comply with COMDTINST.
What types of PSIs are there?	• FPs – basic or entry level • NACLIC – higher level
What is the purpose of the fingerprinting?	To validate: • Citizenship • No felony convictions • Determine eligibility for membership
What does the Operational Support (OS) Fingerprint (FP) check consist of?	The OS Personnel Security Investigation (PSI) package consists of the following forms: • Fingerprint Cards (FD-258) - 2 cards completely filled out, using the Director as the employer address. • Office of Federal Investigations (OFI) Form-86C (Special Agreement Check). ▪ American (by birth) citizens need to fill out 1 through 6, 13.a and 13.b. ▪ Naturalized citizens need to fill out 1 through 6, 13.a, 13.b, and 13.c. ▪ Dual citizens need to fill out 1 through 6, 13.a, 13.b, 13.c, and 13.d. ▪ Coast Guard Security Center (SECCEN) will fill out the remaining blocks. • Standard Form-85 - Authorization For Release of Information (page 6 only).
What is the purpose of the National Agency Check with Law and Credit (NACLIC)?	• All that is included in the FP check. • Establishes eligibility for SECRET clearance. • Determines eligibility to participate in DO missions of the Auxiliary.
What does the NACLIC DO PSI package consist of?	The Direct Operational (DO) PSI package is the standard National Agency Check with Law and Credit (NACLIC), consisting of the following forms: • Questionnaire for National Security Positions (SF-86) - 2 copies, both with original signatures • Fair Credit Reporting Act (DOT Form-1631) • Fingerprint Cards (FD-258), 3 cards
What are the two categories of Auxiliarist participation?	• Direct Operational (DO) • Operational Support (OS)



What is Direct Operational (DO)?	DO is defined as Auxiliarists whose qualifications involve the following: • Surface Operations • Air Operations • Operations Planning • Interpreters • Command Center/OPCEN/COMMS Watchstanding • Fixed/Mobile Radio Facility Operators • Port Security • Marine Safety and Security • Health Care Professionals who are CGAUX Volunteers (G-WK program supported by <i>Coast Guard Auxiliarist Participation in Coast Guard Health Care Activities</i>, COMDTINST 6010.2 (series)) • Some Auxiliary Staff Officers (as determined by active duty Operational Commander, Director of Auxiliary, or the Chief Director) • As directed by a Coast Guard Operational Commander
What is Operational Support (OS)?	• The balance of the Auxiliary membership and their activities.
Is it purely by my job or by my location as well to determine “Direct Operational” or “Operational Support”?	• The Director or local Operational Commander will make qualifications and determination of DO.
What is an Auxiliary Security Screener/Processor? (This position may not exist in all regions.)	Auxiliarist trained to: • Take FPs. • Guide other Auxiliarists in the completion of the NACLC package. • Perform quality check of the NACLC package. • Forward forms to the Director.
Will my FP card be sent immediately from the Director’s office to the SECCEN, or will there be monthly mailings?	• The final decision on mailings to the SECCEN will be determined by the Director. • However, the Director will ensure that timely mailings will be made to the SECCEN.
How will I be notified that my security check was approved?	• The SECCEN will inform the originating Director when approved.



What is the last date I can accept or decline participation?	- The deadline is set by the Commandant (G-OCX). - Individual District/region Directors may designate an earlier date with deadlines for disenrollments. - Auxiliarists will: - Be given one last opportunity to complete acceptance/denial form through contact from a member of their flotilla. Making this contact is an Auxiliary flotilla responsibility prior to the June/July timeframe. (Optional) be notified before they are disenrolled for failure to respond.
What if I declined to participate prior to the date established above and I have changed my mind?	An Auxiliarist can change his/her response: - Prior to/or the date set by your director for submission of the new personnel security questionnaire. - By participating at the appropriate level.
How long does the process take?	- FPS—up to 60 days after receipt at SECCEN. - NACLC—120 days after signature. Caveat: These processes have not been tested with the Auxiliary yet or with this volume. These times may need to be adjusted.
What if I declined to participate and change my mind after the established date above?	You will be reinstated according to the rules and procedures outlined in this manual with submission of FP cards.
What if I responded I would participate but at the wrong level?	Contact your director.
What if I prefer to downgrade to the OS level?	Contact your director.
Will I get a clearance as a result of the NACLC process?	- Not necessarily. - The NACLC makes an Auxiliarist eligible for a clearance. - Clearances are based on the NEED TO KNOW and access to classified information. Clearance need/request will be determined and processed by the Operational Commander through existing Coast Guard policy.
When can I submit my paperwork?	- When directed/requested by the Director. - This is a three-year process. - The ALCOAST assigns each district a monthly quota of FPS to submit to SECCEN and another quota for NACLC packages. - This quota system is necessary to manage the flow of paperwork into the SECCEN.



When can I be fingerprinted and/or get to complete an NACLC package?	- You may be fingerprinted anytime that is convenient to you and the cards may be forwarded to the Director when requested. - FP cards are not time sensitive. - The NACLC package is quite different. The SF-86 must be received by OPM within 120 days of signature. Do not, repeat do NOT complete and sign your forms until you have been told to do so. Member should keep their own copy.
Many of the Auxiliary received the e-letter from the Chief Director's office that stated the form was already on the web for downloading but not to do anything until further notice from your director. Should members start filling them out?	- You may fill out the form(s) but must wait until directed by the Director to sign and date the SF-86. - However, you must ensure that at the time of signing and dating, all of the information you provided is current and accurate.
Where will forms be available?	- Auxiliary National Supply Center (ANSC). - Some local Coast Guard Commands. - DIRAUX. - Auxiliary Security Processor (if position exists in your district). www.uscgaux.org/~forms/test/sec_test.html (with the exception of FP cards).
If I am Direct Operational but will not submit an NACLC until next year, should I be fingerprinted when I have the opportunity?	- You may be fingerprinted anytime that is convenient to you and the cards may be forwarded to the Director when directed. - Three FP cards are required for the Direct Operational PSI. - You must wait until directed by the Director to submit your completed, signed, and dated SF-86 or SF-86C.
I am concerned about the financial disclosure. Why is it necessary for them to look into my credit?	- This is a requirement for all members of the Coast Guard to ensure that there are no financial matters that could cause you to be influenced by someone or do something due to your need for money. - The Privacy Act applies to all personal information and will not be disclosed, except as agreed upon by you when submitting your paperwork.
What is a credit check?	- Credit search of National Credit Bureau (7 years). - This consists of a credit check with Equifax, TRW, and Trans Union, just like at a car dealership or a job application.
If I have poor credit, will I be disenrolled?	No, but it may influence your ability to participate at the DO.



What if I have some “skeletons” in my closet?	• Be completely honest on all questions/all forms. • 80% of all NACLCS have “issues” that require adjudication. (see definition of adjudication in the definition section). • Of those investigations that have “issues”, only 1% of the 80% result in being considered by the SECCEN as an unacceptable security risk (e. g., UNFAV).
Who are the adjudicators, where are they located, and what do they do?	• Coast Guard active duty, civilian employees, and Government contractors who have been trained and certified, just as is done for active duty and civilian investigations. • SECCEN, Chesapeake, VA. • Adjudicators research each case, request additional information/documents, and evaluate the circumstances of each case. • Adjudicators may contact you direct to resolve any issues.
What if I commit a felony after these initial checks?	• SECCEN is notified by the FBI on all felony charges/warrants/arrests. • The Director will be advised for appropriate action in accordance with current directives.
What if I already have an investigation/clearance from a Federal Agency?	• SECCEN will pursue obtaining your current investigation. This applies primarily to current or recent Federal clearances. Coordinate this with your director.
What if I live an hour and a half away from my local flotilla and do not get to the meetings when the FPs are done?	• Please notify your Division’s Auxiliary Security Processor (optional position) or chain of leadership and management who will work with the Director.
Why the thoroughness/depth of the “check”?	• The thoroughness/depth is to ensure compliance with Executive Orders and DHS standards to help ensure the security of the United States and the reliability of those that serve such as Auxiliarists, Coast Guard, DHS, DoD, etc.
If I am outside of my area, district, or division (e. g., snowbirds), will that make a difference in submitting the form?	• Auxiliarists should be processed by their home District/region director’s office but may be assisted by the local Division. • This is a three-year process. If you are going to be out of your home area for more than three years, please contact your director to make alternative arrangements.
Do I have to have a picture ID before I can submit the form?	• A valid picture ID must be available upon request.
What if I have traveled extensively over the past 7 years and there is not adequate space to report this on the form.	• On the SF-86, page 9 has a continuation section to include information that did not fit in that particular block.



As a prospective member, do I pay my dues prior to having an approved security check?	• Yes, the check will be retained at the flotilla level until the check has been completed and approved.
Should I buy and wear a Coast Guard AUX uniform prior to receiving my approved security background check? What can I do as a prospective member?	• No, you may participate in all non-operational Auxiliary activities and can attend all meetings and public education training sessions, but you may not wear a uniform until you have a completed and approved security background check.
Before I receive my approved security background check, will I be processed by the Director's office for things such as a member number?	• No, not until you receive the approved security background check.
After 1 February, what kind of interim status can I (as a prospective member) be given while the Director's office awaits the results of my FPs from SECCEN? Can I get an interim ID, participate in training, get underway, etc.?	• You can participate in all non-operational Auxiliary activities/in processing, etc. No ID card will be issued until FP check is completed.
After 1 February, can I be qualified/certified as air/boat crew members (or other DO) prior to the SECCEN adjudicating my security package? (According to the ALCOAST, the answer is no).	• A new member, who has a favorable FP check and has properly submitted all paperwork for a PSI, may receive an interim certification as an operational air/boat crewmember (or other DO) upon completion of appropriate qualifications by the Director /Operational CO. This interim certification is at the discretion of the Director upon favorable review of the member's SF-86 with no glaring issues.
If my FPs are submitted for FP check purposes and are favorable, then I go Direct Operational, do FPs need to be submitted with SF-86?	• In most cases no, since the SECCEN already holds your FPs on file they will submit with the SF-86 and DOT 1631.
Why does the Coast Guard need FPs? Why can't the Coast Guard just run an NCIC check using name/SSN/DOB?	• There may be persons who have "unknown" FPs in the FBI's system that will be identified by these checks. • The information provided on the FP card will also be used for citizenship verification.
Can SECCEN accept FPs sent electronically?	• No, there is no mechanism in place to accept cards or prints electronically.
Are budget resources being diverted from other Auxiliary needs to pay for the checks? Where is the funding coming from?	• No, special funding is being provided by the Coast Guard.



How long is my signature valid on the SF-86?	• The signature is indefinite if received by OPM within 120 days. Submission will be directed by the Director. • Do not complete the SF-86 until directed to do so by the Director. Do not sign or date the form until directed to do so by the Director. • Completion of the SF-86 and the signing and dating should occur at nearly the same time to ensure the form information is still current at time of signing.
Are new members being included in the monthly quota?	• No, they will be processed as they join.
Can the FP card be folded to fit into an envelope?	• No, the card cannot be folded.
How long are the PSIs good for?	• Operational Support (FP check)-lifetime. • Direct Operational (NACLC): ▪ Basic security check–lifetime. ▪ Clearance issued–every 10 years.
What, if any, Privacy Act considerations are there/should there be with letting the Auxiliary leadership know: (a) who failed to respond, and (b) who declined on the 15 January form?	• None. There are no Privacy Act considerations.
If I did not mail the form in as my way of “opting out,” can I be advised of this for disenrollment purposes?	• Yes.
Where do I send FP cards for new applications?	• To your director, and the director will send it directly to the SECCEN.
Could I be IQ (Initially Qualified) and not BQ (Basically Qualified) until after the security check is completed?	• Prospective members can participate in only non-operational activities until the FP check is completed. • Full membership is contingent upon a FAV check.
How long will it really take for me to get a response?	• We hope FP checks will be completed with results returned within 60 days.
If I were a coxswain on a lake 300 miles from a Coast Guard station, do I have to complete the SF-86?	• Yes, as a coxswain your qualifications make you DO.



I am worried about ensuring the care, custody, and control of my FP card once the prints have been taken. What guidance is the Coast Guard giving on ensuring care, custody, and control of FP cards once the prints have been taken? A basic security check keyperson in the district has stated that he does not believe the individual should be allowed to mail the cards in, as there is potential for fraud in the arrangement. He said this is a big issue for police departments.	Director s can send out guidance stating: • Individuals taking the prints must put the cards in the envelopes, not the member getting fingerprinted. Otherwise, this issue has not been deemed to be of significant problem by the Director of Coast Guard Security (CG-86). • SECCEN has never had an issue with any of the tens of thousands of active duty, Reserve, or civilian packages they have processed to date. • The Director and the SECCEN will work together to ensure that security is maximized.
What is the possibility of fraud if unknown persons (police officers or other non-Auxiliarists) take my prints, especially one-on-one?	• There is always that possibility, but if a person is going to a local police department, there has to be a certain level of trust established by the position entrusted to those law enforcement officials. • Positive ID is required by the authority taking prints.
Is there any chance of ID theft in this process once it gets into the Coast Guard's hands?	• There are many opportunities to be a victim of identity theft, but this process should be the least of anyone's worries because there are many internal safeguards. • The people who handle the data are themselves vetted to a high standard. We have never had an issue with any one of the tens of thousands of active duty, Reserve, and civilian folks we have processed to date.
Do I have to pay to get my FPs taken? Should I pay?	• Absolutely not. The National Commodore and the Chief Director have declared that their intention is for no Auxiliarist to have to pay to get the fingerprinting accomplished. • Nearly \$10000 worth of fingerprinting kits are being distributed throughout the nation to the Director's offices for further allocation within the district. • Other LE agencies may take prints for free after being contacted by the local Auxiliary leadership or Coast Guard Director's staff. Coordinating with local LE agencies or their "Police Auxiliary" to get FPs accomplished at no cost has been an integral "part" of the overall FP plan.
Is there a difference between a PSI and a security clearance?	• Yes, a PSI is the actual investigation that will be performed on Auxiliarists as a result of their status as either OS or DO. • The PSI for OS personnel will be based on the FP check to basically verify citizenship and potential felony history. • The PSI for DO personnel will be based on the FP check and the NACLC to verify citizenship and felony history, as well as, history with LE, national agencies, and credit agencies.



What is the Coast Guard Security Center?	The Coast Guard SECCEN serves as the Central Adjudicating Facility (CAF) for the processing, determination, and maintenance of all Coast Guard personnel security files.
Am I required to supply a Social Security Number for the background check?	- Yes, OPM will not process the form without an SSN. There is too much of an opportunity to mistake the identity using just names. - The “laws” and Federal regulations that govern the background checks do, in fact, require SSNs for the legitimate reason stated.
What is the acceptable form of ID for me as a member or prospective member?	A driver’s license, retired military ID, or other form of recognized ID.
Will my approved background security check be entered into AUXDATA?	Yes.
I heard that the Special Agreement Check (SAC) (OFI Form-86C) has to be completed with the Operational Support FP Card submittal. What is this form, and do I need to do it?	- No, you do not need to complete this form because SECCEN will do it. - Any FP cards that have already been collected without this information will have to be annotated with that information by the Director.
Even though the SECCEN will be following up on whether the Auxiliarist has a clearance on file with another Federal agency, does the Director need to forward anything on to the SECCEN?	No, unless additional documentation beyond the acceptance/denial form is needed and requested by the SECCEN.



Besides the likely disenrollment if some sufficiently negative information turns up as a result of my personnel security check, are there any other potential impacts for me? For example, if the person holds a merchant mariner license, would any negative information be shared with the licensing community (possibly resulting in the revocation of my license)? Or, put another way, will the results of this background check effort be used solely, strictly, and confidentially for Auxiliary purposes?	• Derogatory information will be passed in memo form from the SECCEN to the Director. • Additionally, the Coast Guard is obligated to pass that derogatory info on to the Marine Bureau Index (MBI) that feeds back to the Coast Guard for the tracking of Merchant Mariner Document (MMD) cards. • Depending on the derogatory, it could result in the suspension of their license. Common sense should apply - that if the information attained is derogatory and results in a revocation (after due process), the person probably is not suitable for the Auxiliary. • All personnel must remember that submission and completion of FP cards, SF-86, etc enters the person into the Federal system/data base. Auxiliarists like others who go through this process should have no expectation that the Coast Guard will keep this info just to itself. • All info is eligible for official sharing to other Federal agencies for official purposes if and as needed.
Our municipal police department and county detention center offered to provide fingerprinting to our members free of charge. Their equipment captures the FP digitally and prints the results onto cards. Providing the official Coast Guard's card format is compatible with their equipment, is this method acceptable for Coast Guard/OPM/FBI and overall Auxiliary Personnel Security vetting process? In other words, is this electronic scanning and automatic printing acceptable or is the "old fashioned" tried-and-true ink process the only acceptable procedure?	Electronic method of taking and printing FPs is fine and meets all needs as long as the ink/image on the card is in black ink, and is on the correct FD-258 FP Card with the Coast Guard's agency (ORI) code (DCCG00100). NOTE  This process is acceptable as long as the FP taker does not run the print thru the heating pad - causing the black ink to turn red.



When I submitted/returned my Personnel Security Questionnaire (PSQ), I claimed I have a prior Federal PSI which has not expired, and that based on that PSI, I hold a valid current Federal clearance. I know these FAQs say SECCEN will follow up on this after my form is received by the SECCEN from my Director. But, do I or my Director/OTO need to send anything forward on me or my claim other than the initial PSQ?	No, not if the SECCEN verified that you have a valid clearance. If there is more action/paperwork required by the SECCEN, they will let the Director's office know.
What race codes should Hispanic or Latino Auxiliarists use on their FP card? On the card, there is "I" for Indian, "W" for White, "A" for Asian, "B" for Black, and "U" for unknown.	Per Guidelines for Preparation of Criminal Justice Information Services Division FP Cards (Revised Sept 94), regarding Hispanic/Latino for race, the code to use is "W".
How long is an investigation "good" after I retire from Federal service?	24 months.
Why can't the Coast Guard accept FPs submitted for a mariner's license?	Those forms are not processed at U.S. OPM, SECCEN does not have access to that information.
Are FPs from anywhere (mariner's license, etc.) good enough?	Only if the FPs are submitted and held by U.S. OPM due to an investigation request.
Where do the mariner's license FPs go?	They are submitted directly to the FBI.
Will remaining OS affect my eligibility to serve in either staff or elected positions?	No, once elected a decision will have to be made if you meet the requirements for a DO. NOTE  National Staff positions require DO.



As a prospective applicant, how will I be entered into AUXDATA when I am awaiting the results of my PSI?	• A prospective applicant status of “AP–Applicant” has been created in AUXDATA. • As a stop-gap measure, a new “Approval Pending” division and flotilla (xxx-99-99) were also added to each district. • This will allow the prospective applicant record to be created in AUXDATA, and Employee ID assigned, but that person will not appear in AUXDATA, except in the new “Approval Pending” area. • When a favorable PSI is complete and members become eligible for DO or OS, the status is to be changed from AP to IQ or BQ and the new member is transferred to their new flotilla. • The status of AP will not count against the number of members in the Auxiliary. • This is all only a stop-gap measure until completion of the new Security Module, and associated screens and reports.
What is the shelf-life of the signature for the “Authorization for Release of Information”?	• 2 years.
What is the shelf-life of the signature for the OFI Form-86C?	• There is none. The only signature on the OFI Form-86C is for the SECCEN representative requesting the PSI.